SkillNavora Academy · Chapter 6 of 19

Search Engine Optimization (SEO)

Beginner-to-advanced study guide, 26-point checklist, workbook, quiz and roadmap

Written by Varun, for SkillNavora · Draft

Official site: www.skillnavora.in

Prepared for Skillnavora — Learn. Practise. Implement. Grow.

CHAPTER 6 OF 19

Search Engine Optimization (SEO)

Learn SEO step by step: how search works, how to research keywords, how to optimise pages, how to earn links honestly, and how to rank for local searches. Written by Varun for SkillNavora.

Core objective

Plan, implement, measure and improve SEO with a 26-point checklist. SEO is a long-term channel. It does not guarantee first-page rankings.

Four pillars

Pillar	What you do
Understand	How search works, intent, relevance, authority and experience.
Create	Keyword research, page structure, titles, content and links.
Implement	GA4, Search Console, sitemap, WordPress SEO settings, audits.
Optimise	Measure, diagnose, refresh and improve.

Three dimensions of SEO

- **Relevance:** does the page match the searcher's question?
- **Authority and trust:** is the site credible, with good links?
- **Technical access and experience:** can search engines crawl, index and use the page?

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HOW THIS GUIDE WAS CHECKED

Google's official pages could not be opened from the workspace used to write this. Current facts are from Google's published guidance as known at writing. Tool plans, search features and third-party metrics change. Verify each item before you rely on it.

FRONT MATTER

Copyright and learning objectives

Learning objectives for this chapter, and what you should be able to do afterwards.

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Objectives

- Explain how search works and why SEO is a long-term channel.
- Set up GA4, Search Console and a sitemap.
- Research, filter and map keywords to pages.
- Optimise titles, URLs, descriptions, headings, images and links.
- Earn links ethically and avoid spam practices.
- Optimise a local business profile.
- Measure, diagnose and improve results over 30, 60 and 90 days.

No part of this guide guarantees a ranking. Google's documentation, plans and screens change; verify before you act.

PART A · PLAIN GUIDE FOR BEGINNERS

Simple SEO guide for beginners in India

Short sections, plain words, and one action for each topic.

1. Why search traffic matters and how Google ranks pages

Search brings people who are already looking. Google ranks pages using relevance (does the page match the search?), authority (do trusted sites link to it?), and clicks and experience (do people find it useful?).

- Search visitors are often ready to act.
- Relevance: match the searcher's words and intent.
- Authority and trust come from good content and links from other sites.
- SEO is slow. Expect months, not days.

DO THIS WEEK

Search 'best [your product] in India' and note the top three pages, their type and what they answer.

2. Measuring SEO: traffic, conversions and Search Console

Measure organic traffic (visits from search), conversions (sign-ups, calls, purchases) and visibility (how often you appear).

- Google Analytics 4 shows organic traffic.
- Search Console shows impressions, clicks, click-through rate and average position.
- One SEO tool, such as Ubersuggest (free and paid plans), helps with keyword ideas.

DO THIS WEEK

Create a Search Console account and add your site. Note your current impressions and clicks.

3. Technical basics

Search Console setup, a sitemap (a list of your pages for Google), page speed, and a mobile check.

- Verify your site in Search Console.
- Submit your sitemap.
- Test speed in PageSpeed Insights. Aim for 80 or more as a useful target, not a rule.
- Check your site on your own phone.

DO THIS WEEK

Submit your sitemap and run PageSpeed Insights on your homepage.

4. Keyword research

Brainstorm ideas, check search volume and cost per click, then pick long-tail keywords (longer, specific phrases with clear intent).

- Collect 50 ideas from Google suggestions and 'People also ask'.
- Check volume and cost per click in Google Keyword Planner. Volumes are ranges.

- Pick long-tail phrases you can realistically rank for.

DO THIS WEEK

Write 50 keyword ideas and pick five long-tail phrases for one page.

5. On-page SEO

One main keyword per page. Title about 55 characters, description about 155, a short URL, clear headings, image alt text, internal links and at least 300 words where the topic needs them.

- Title: main topic first, about 50 to 60 characters. Google may rewrite it.
- Description: about 150 to 160 characters, states the benefit.
- URL: short, with hyphens.
- Headings: one H1, then H2s. Add alt text to images. Link related pages.

DO THIS WEEK

Optimise one page: title, description, URL, headings, one image and two internal links.

6. Link building

Earn quality links from relevant sites. Dofollow links are normal links; nofollow links carry a hint that the link should not be endorsed. Guest posts on relevant sites can earn links.

- Earn links with useful content.
- Guest posts on relevant sites, written honestly.
- Avoid paid link packages and spam: they break Google's spam policies.

DO THIS WEEK

Find three relevant sites in your field that accept guest posts. Read their rules.

7. Local SEO

Google Business Profile, the same name, address and phone everywhere (NAP), reviews, and local directories.

- Create and verify your Google Business Profile.
- Keep Name, Address and Phone exactly the same on every listing.
- Ask happy customers for reviews and reply to all of them.

DO THIS WEEK

Claim or check your Google Business Profile and write down three details to correct.

TOOL CHANGES

Tools, free plans and screens change. Check each tool's own site before you rely on its features: Google Search Console, Google Analytics, Google Business Profile, Yoast SEO and Ubersuggest all update often. The Mobile-Friendly Test is discontinued; use PageSpeed Insights and real-phone checks instead.

CHAPTER OVERVIEW · TOOLS

SEO tools: what each does, how to use it, and its limits

You do not need paid tools for basic SEO. Start with the free ones. Check current plans on each official site.

Tool	Purpose	Free or paid	How a beginner uses it	Output	Limitations	Alternatives
Google Analytics 4 developers.google.com/analytics	Traffic and conversions	Free	Connect your site, then check the organic channel report each week.	Organic traffic report and conversion counts	Needs correct tags and events; data is not instant.	Plausible or Matomo (check their plans)
Google Search Console search.google.com/search-console/about	Search visibility and indexing	Free	Verify, submit sitemap, read Performance and Indexing reports.	Impressions, clicks, average position, indexing issues	Shows Google data only; no full keyword list for free.	Bing Webmaster Tools
PageSpeed Insights pagespeed.web.dev	Speed and Core Web Vitals	Free	Paste a URL, read the opportunities list, fix the top one.	Scores and a fix list	Scores vary between runs; lab data is a test, not real users.	GTmetrix (check plans)
Google Keyword Planner ads.google.com/home/tools/keyword-planner	Keyword volume ranges and CPC	Free with a Google Ads account	Enter seed topics, download ideas, note ranges.	Ideas with volume ranges and CPC	Ranges depend on account and settings; not exact.	Ubersuggest, Ahrefs
Ahrefs ahrefs.com	Backlinks and keyword research	Paid, trial options (check)	Enter a competitor domain, check referring domains.	Backlink and keyword lists	Costly; third-party data may differ from Google.	Moz, Majestic, Ubersuggest
Moz moz.com	Keyword and link metrics (DA, PA)	Free tools and paid (check)	Use MozBar on a SERP to see metrics.	DA and PA comparison scores	DA and PA are not Google ranking factors.	Ahrefs, Ubersuggest
Ubersuggest neilpatel.com/ubersuggest (check)	Keyword ideas and basic audits	Free and paid (check)	Enter a keyword, read ideas and difficulty.	Keyword ideas list	Free limits; data is an estimate.	Keyword Planner
Majestic majestic.com	Backlink analysis	Paid (check)	Enter a domain, review Trust and Citation metrics.	Backlink lists	Third-party metrics; not Google's.	Ahrefs, Moz

Yoast SEO yoast.com	WordPress SEO settings	Free plugin; paid tiers (check)	Install, set titles and descriptions per page.	Titles, descriptions, sitemap	Guidance is not a guarantee; plugin updates change screens.	Rank Math (check)
Canva canva.com	Graphics for posts and images	Free and paid	Choose a template, set size, export at a sensible size.	Images and graphics	Licensed assets vary; check each.	Figma, Pixlr
BuzzSumo buzzsumo.com	Content and topic research	Paid (check)	Search a topic, sort by shares, read top pieces.	Top content list	Shares are not rankings.	Google Trends, AnswerThePublic (check)
Similarweb similarweb.com	Traffic estimates	Free and paid (estimates)	Enter a domain, compare traffic channels.	Estimated channel mix	Estimates; not measured data.	Compare with your own GA4
Google Business Profile business.google.com	Local listing and reviews	Free	Claim, verify, complete the profile, reply to reviews.	Complete local profile	Verification and features change.	Bing Places (check)
Screaming Frog SEO Spider screamingfrog.co.uk/seo-spider	Site crawl for technical issues	Free up to a limit; paid (check)	Enter a URL, run a crawl, filter by errors.	Broken links, titles, redirects list	Large sites need the paid version.	Sitebulb, Google Search Console reports
Bing Webmaster Tools bing.com/webmasters	Bing search data and sitemaps	Free	Verify, submit sitemap.	Bing indexing and search data	Bing traffic is smaller than Google's in many markets.	Google Search Console
Rich Results Test search.google.com/test/rich-results	Structured data test	Free	Paste a URL or code, read errors and warnings.	Eligibility for rich results	Passing the test does not guarantee a rich result.	Schema Markup Validator
Yoast and Rank Math sitemaps (in WordPress plugins)	Sitemap generation	Free	Turn on sitemap in plugin settings.	Sitemap address	Check the address works.	Built-in WordPress sitemap features (check)

CHECK FIRST

Tool features and prices change. Each entry was not checked live from this workspace.

CHAPTER OVERVIEW · 26-POINT CHECKLIST

The 26-point SEO implementation checklist

Four stages, 26 points. Use it as your project plan.

Each point has why it matters, steps, the tool, the expected output, how to verify it, the common mistake and a Done box.

Stage A: Technical foundations

POINT 1: INSTALL AND CONFIGURE GA4

Why it matters: Track visits and conversions so you can see organic results.

Steps:

1. Create a GA4 property and a web data stream.
2. Install the tag with your WordPress integration or Google Tag Manager.
3. Mark key actions (form submit, purchase) as conversion events.

Tool: Google Analytics 4 (free)
Expected output: Realtime report shows your visit
Verify by: Open GA4 on your phone, load your site, check Realtime.
Common mistake: Missing tag; unclear conversion events.

☐ Done

POINT 2: INSTALL AND CONFIGURE YOAST SEO

Why it matters: Set titles, descriptions and sitemap settings in one place.

Steps:

1. Install and activate the plugin.
2. Set site name and homepage title and description.
3. Check the XML sitemap is on and note its address.

Tool: Yoast SEO (free plugin; paid tiers)
Expected output: Sitemap page opens in a browser
Verify by: Open the sitemap address and confirm it lists pages.
Common mistake: Treating Yoast's green lights as guaranteed rankings.

☐ Done

POINT 3: VERIFY SEARCH CONSOLE

Why it matters: Monitor indexing, clicks and sitemap errors.

Steps:

1. Add a Domain or URL-prefix property.
2. Verify with DNS or an HTML tag, as the method offers.
3. Submit the sitemap under Sitemaps.

Tool: Google Search Console (free)
Expected output: Property verified and sitemap status shows Success
Verify by: Check the Sitemaps report after 2 days.
Common mistake: Verifying the wrong property type.

☐ Done

POINT 4: AUDIT PAGE PERFORMANCE

Why it matters: Find slow pages and fix the biggest causes first.

Steps:

1. Test three key URLs in PageSpeed Insights.
2. Note LCP, INP and CLS, and whether data is lab or field.
3. Fix the largest image or script first, then retest.

Tool: PageSpeed Insights (free)
Expected output: A list of three fixes with scores before and after
Verify by: Retest the same URL after each change.
Common mistake: Testing once and never retesting.

☐ Done

POINT 5: MOBILE USABILITY

Why it matters: Make sure people can use pages on a phone.

Steps:

1. Open key pages on a real phone.
2. Check menus, buttons and forms with a thumb.
3. Check text size and sideways scrolling.

Tool: Real phone, browser device view, PageSpeed Insights
Expected output: List of mobile issues with a fix for each
Verify by: Repeat on two phone sizes.
Common mistake: Relying on the discontinued Mobile-Friendly Test.

☐ Done

POINT 6: TECHNICAL HEALTH

Why it matters: Make sure search engines can reach and understand your pages.

Steps:

1. Check the site uses HTTPS.
2. Open robots.txt and check important pages are not blocked.
3. Find broken links and 404 pages; fix or redirect them.

Tool: Search Console, browser, a crawler (Screaming Frog, free up to a limit)
Expected output: Technical issues list with priorities
Verify by: Check with a crawl after fixes.
Common mistake: Redirect chains and blocked important pages.

☐ Done

Stage B: Keyword research

POINT 7: DEFINE AUDIENCE AND INTENT

Why it matters: Know who you serve and what they search for.

Steps:

1. Write one buyer persona with their problem in their words.
2. List the questions they ask before buying.
3. Label each question informational or commercial.

Tool: Notes or spreadsheet
Expected output: One persona and a labelled question list
Verify by: Compare with real customer words from surveys.
Common mistake: Guessing the customer.

☐ Done

POINT 8: GENERATE KEYWORD IDEAS

Why it matters: Build a long list of relevant ideas.

Steps:

1. Collect suggestions from Google autocomplete and People also ask.
2. Add ideas from community threads and your survey.
3. Expand with Ubersuggest or Keyword Planner if you use them.

Tool: Google autocomplete, Keyword Planner, Ubersuggest
Expected output: 50+ rows in a spreadsheet
Verify by: Remove irrelevant rows.
Common mistake: Keeping unrelated ideas to make the list longer.

☐ Done

POINT 9: FILTER AND PRIORITISE

Why it matters: Pick keywords you can realistically target.

Steps:

1. Add volume range, CPC, intent and relevance columns.
2. Score each row and keep the top ten.
3. Explain the score to yourself in one sentence each.

Tool: Keyword Planner, spreadsheet
Expected output: Top ten with scores
Verify by: Check the top ten against the SERP.
Common mistake: Chasing volume alone.

☐ Done

POINT 10: COMPETITOR ANALYSIS AND MAPPING

Why it matters: Find content gaps and assign one URL per keyword.

Steps:

1. Search each top keyword and note the page types.
2. Compare depth and missing questions with your planned page.
3. Fill a keyword-to-URL map.

Tool: Manual SERP check, Ahrefs or Moz (paid or trial)
Expected output: Keyword-to-URL map
Verify by: Each URL has exactly one main keyword.
Common mistake: Using DA or DR as a promise.

☐ Done

Stage C: On-page SEO

POINT 11: TITLE TAGS

Why it matters: Write a clear, true title for each page.

Steps:

1. Put the main topic near the start.
2. Add a benefit or modifier where true (guide, comparison).
3. Count characters; aim for about 50 to 60 as a guide.

Tool: Yoast SEO, a character counter
Expected output: Title per page in a table
Verify by: Read the title as a stranger; check it is not cut off.
Common mistake: Keyword stuffing.

☐ Done

POINT 12: URL STRUCTURE

Why it matters: Short, readable web addresses.

Steps:

1. Use lowercase words separated by hyphens.
2. Remove numeric IDs and unnecessary parameters.
3. Redirect the old URL if you change it.

Tool: WordPress permalinks settings
Expected output: URL list
Verify by: Open each URL and check it works.
Common mistake: Changing URLs without redirects.

☐ Done

POINT 13: META DESCRIPTIONS

Why it matters: Summaries that invite a click.

Steps:

1. Summarise the page accurately.
2. Name one benefit and a clear next step.
3. Aim for about 150 to 160 characters as a guide.

Tool: Yoast SEO
Expected output: Description per page, none duplicated
Verify by: Check each description is different.
Common mistake: Duplicate descriptions on many pages.

☐ Done

POINT 14: IMAGES

Why it matters: Fast, described images.

Steps:

1. Name the file with words, for example seo-checklist.webp.
2. Compress and resize; use WebP or AVIF where supported.
3. Write alt text that describes the image; use empty alt for decoration.

Tool: Canva, a compression tool
Expected output: Image log with sizes and alt text
Verify by: Check page weight before and after.
Common mistake: Huge files and missing alt text.

☐ Done

POINT 15: INTRODUCTION

Why it matters: Name the reader's problem early.

Steps:

1. Answer the question in the first two paragraphs.
2. Use the main topic naturally in the first 100 words.
3. Avoid repeating the keyword unnaturally.

Tool: Editor
Expected output: Rewritten introduction
Verify by: Read it aloud: does it answer the question?
Common mistake: Filler before the answer.

☐ Done

POINT 16: HEADINGS

Why it matters: Clear structure for readers.

Steps:

1. One H1 for the main topic.
2. H2 for main sections, H3 for sub-points.
3. Use questions as headings where they match the searcher.

Tool: Editor
Expected output: Heading outline
Verify by: Scan only the headings: do they tell the story?
Common mistake: Choosing headings for their size.

☐ Done

POINT 17: INTERNAL LINKS

Why it matters: Connect related pages.

Steps:

1. Link supporting articles to the main page.
2. Use descriptive anchor text.
3. Find orphan pages and link to them.

Tool: Editor, a crawler
Expected output: Link map
Verify by: Every important page has at least one internal link.
Common mistake: Vague link text such as 'click here'.

☐ Done

POINT 18: EXTERNAL REFERENCES

Why it matters: Support claims with trusted sources.

Steps:

1. Link to official or authoritative sources for facts.
2. Check each link works and is relevant.
3. Do not link to pages only to add numbers.

Tool: Editor
Expected output: Source list
Verify by: Click every source.
Common mistake: Irrelevant links for appearance.

☐ Done

POINT 19: USEFUL CONTENT

Why it matters: Answer the searcher's intent fully.

Steps:

1. Write a content brief from the search results.
2. Add examples, steps and a short FAQ.
3. Remove filler sentences.

Tool: Editor, AI tool for drafts (verify output)
Expected output: Content brief and finished page
Verify by: Ask: would a reader need to search again?
Common mistake: Padding to hit a word count.

☐ Done

POINT 20: CONTENT EXPERIENCE

Why it matters: Easy to read and scan.

Steps:

1. Use short paragraphs and clear lists.
2. Add a table or visual where it helps.
3. Make links and buttons easy to tap.

Tool: Editor, phone check
Expected output: Layout check notes
Verify by: Read on a phone.
Common mistake: Walls of text.

☐ Done

POINT 21: SOCIAL SHARING

Why it matters: Good previews when shared.

Steps:

1. Set Open Graph title, description and image.
2. Preview the link in a sharing debugger.
3. Share on platforms your audience uses.

Tool: Yoast SEO, Facebook or LinkedIn sharing preview
Expected output: Preview checked
Verify by: Share a test link.
Common mistake: Assuming social shares rank a page directly.

☐ Done

POINT 22: ON-PAGE AUDIT

Why it matters: A repeatable check of every key page.

Steps:

1. Use one template for every page.
2. Check title, description, H1, URL, images, links, intent and mobile.
3. Record issues and fixes with dates.

Tool: Audit template (see Templates)
Expected output: Completed audit for each key page
Verify by: Re-audit one page after two weeks.
Common mistake: Skipping pages.

☐ Done

Stage D: Off-page, links and local

POINT 23: COMPETITOR BACKLINKS

Why it matters: Find link opportunities.

Steps:

1. Pick three competitors.
2. List their referring domains and page types.
3. Note which links look relevant and useful.

Tool: Ahrefs, Moz or Majestic (paid or trial)
Expected output: Opportunity list
Verify by: Check relevance of each source.
Common mistake: Copying spammy links.

☐ Done

POINT 24: ETHICAL OUTREACH

Why it matters: Ask relevant sites for useful links.

Steps:

1. Find resource pages that match your topic.
2. Send a short, personal email with one resource.
3. Track replies in a spreadsheet.

Tool: Email, spreadsheet
Expected output: Contact log
Verify by: Follow up once, politely.
Common mistake: Mass spam emails or paid placements.

☐ Done

POINT 25: LINK-WORTHY ASSETS

Why it matters: Create things people want to link to.

Steps:

1. Pick one asset: a guide, calculator or original data.
2. Plan who would benefit from it.
3. Publish with real sources.

Tool: Research, Canva, spreadsheet
Expected output: Asset plan
Verify by: Check every number has a source.
Common mistake: Inventing data.

☐ Done

POINT 26: LOCAL SEO AND BUSINESS PROFILE

Why it matters: Accurate local presence.

Steps:

1. Claim and verify your Google Business Profile.
2. Choose categories, hours, services and photos.
3. Keep Name, Address and Phone identical on listings and ask for reviews.

Tool: Google Business Profile (free)
Expected output: Complete profile and NAP check
Verify by: Compare the profile with your website.
Common mistake: Mismatched details across listings.

☐ Done

LECTURE 6.1 · PILLARS: UNDERSTAND

What SEO is and why it matters

Explain SEO in plain words and why it can bring visitors who are already looking for what you sell.

Learning objective

Explain SEO in plain words and why it can bring visitors who are already looking for what you sell.

SEO means search engine optimisation: making your pages easier for search engines to understand, trust and show to the right people. Organic search results are the free results, not the ads.

- Search brings people who are actively looking, so the visit is often more useful than a random social visit.
- Good SEO is a slow, steady channel. It is not a guaranteed first-page result.

CURRENT SEO PRACTICE / VERIFY

Google's own SEO Starter Guide is the best free starting point: developers.google.com/search/docs/fundamentals/seo-starter-guide



Crawling, indexing and ranking are different steps

Practice

Write down three searches you made this week that could have led to a business you run or want to run.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Is SEO a guaranteed way to reach page 1?
   Answer: No. Results depend on competition, quality and many other signals.
2. What does organic mean in search?
   Answer: Free, non-paid results.

Key takeaways

- SEO is about relevance, trust and a good experience.
- Search visitors are often ready to act.
- SEO is slow and steady, not instant.

The four strategic questions

Answer four questions that decide whether SEO is worth your time: search traffic, intent, how search works, and clicks.

Learning objective

Answer four questions that decide whether SEO is worth your time: search traffic, intent, how search works, and clicks.

1. Is search important for websites?

Look at competitors' traffic sources in a tool such as Similarweb. Check whether search is a large share. Treat tool estimates as rough guides.

2. Why can search be valuable?

Compare searches such as *best desktop microphone* or *affordable CRM for small business* with a scrolling feed. The searcher has a problem and wants a solution.

3. How do search engines work?

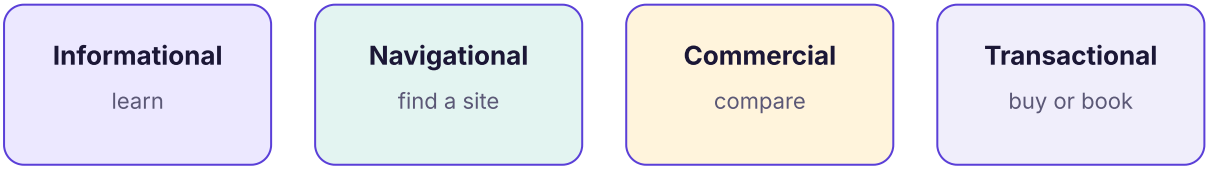
1. Crawling: finding pages.
2. Rendering: understanding the page as a browser shows it.
3. Indexing: storing the page in the search index.
4. Ranking: ordering results for each query by relevance, quality and other signals.
5. Serving: showing results.

4. How do clicks split across results?

Higher positions usually get more clicks. Exact shares vary by query, device, ads and search features. Historical studies gave figures such as about 31 percent for position 1. Treat any such figure as an old example, not a current fact.

CURRENT SEO PRACTICE / VERIFY

Search results now include AI features, videos, maps and snippets, so click shares vary more than before.



Match each page to one intent

Practice

Search five queries in a private window. Note who ranks, what page type they are, and the search intent.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. What are the five steps of search?
   Answer: Crawling, rendering, indexing, ranking and serving.
2. Is a position-1 click share fixed?
   Answer: No. It varies by query and layout.

Key takeaways

- Search intent matters.
- Crawl, index and rank are different steps.
- Click shares change with the results layout.

LECTURE 6.3 · PILLARS: OPTIMISE

Five metrics to measure SEO

Measure SEO with five numbers: organic traffic, conversions, revenue, backlinks and keyword visibility.

Learning objective

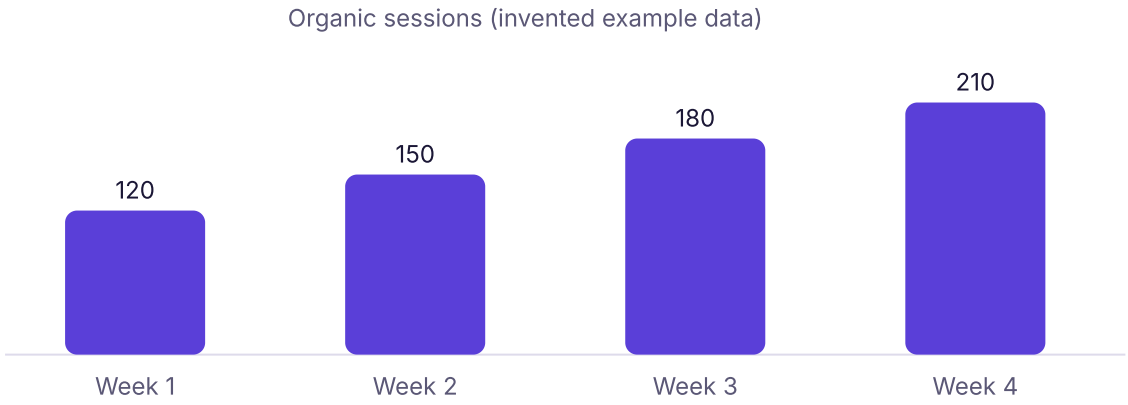
Measure SEO with five numbers: organic traffic, conversions, revenue, backlinks and keyword visibility.

1. Organic traffic: in Google Analytics 4, check Reports, then Acquisition, then Traffic acquisition, and look at Organic Search.
2. Organic conversions: sign-ups, enquiries or purchases from organic visits. Set these up as events.
3. Organic revenue: for shops, revenue from organic visits.
4. Backlinks: track new and lost referring domains.
5. Keyword visibility: in Search Console, track impressions, clicks, click-through rate and average position.

Illustrative dashboard

Metric	Week 1 (example)	Week 4 (example)
Organic sessions	120	210
Organic enquiries	3	7
Search impressions	4,100	6,800

These numbers are invented for practice.



Practice

Build a one-page dashboard for your site with these five rows and fill in your own numbers when you have them.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Which Search Console numbers show visibility?
   Answer: Impressions, clicks, click-through rate and average position.
2. Why separate organic from paid?
   Answer: So you know what search itself delivers.

Key takeaways

- Track five numbers, not fifty.
- Organic needs its own report.
- Use real data, and label examples as examples.

LECTURE 6.4 · PILLARS: CREATE · IMPLEMENT

Homepage SEO

Write a homepage title, description and heading that tell search engines and visitors what you offer.

Learning objective

Write a homepage title, description and heading that tell search engines and visitors what you offer.

A simple pattern for a homepage title is **Brand + core offer**, for example *Skillnavora | Complete Digital Marketing Course*.

- Use one H1 that says what the site is for.
- Write a description that states the offer and a benefit, under about 160 characters.
- Link to your key services and course pages from the homepage.
- Show trust: contact details, real reviews, clear policies.

CURRENT SEO PRACTICE / VERIFY

Yoast SEO is a free WordPress plugin with a title and description editor. Check the current free features on its own site: yoast.com

Practice

Write a homepage title and description for your own business and check their length.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. What is a good homepage title pattern?
   Answer: Brand plus core offer.
2. How many H1 headings should a page have?
   Answer: One clear main heading.

Key takeaways

- Brand plus offer in the title.
- One clear H1.
- Link to your key pages.

LECTURE 6.5 · PILLARS: IMPLEMENT · OPTIMISE

Google Search Console setup

Set up Search Console, verify your site, and submit your sitemap.

Learning objective

Set up Search Console, verify your site, and submit your sitemap.

1. Open Google Search Console and sign in.
2. Add a property. Domain property covers all versions of the domain; URL-prefix covers one address pattern.
3. Verify ownership. Domain properties use a DNS record. URL-prefix properties offer methods such as an HTML tag or a plugin like Yoast.
4. Find your sitemap. Yoast often creates sitemap_index.xml, but check your real address in your settings.
5. Submit the sitemap under Sitemaps.
6. Use URL Inspection on your important pages and read the Indexing report.

CURRENT SEO PRACTICE / VERIFY

Search Console menus and verification options change. Check the current Google Search Console Help: support.google.com/webmasters/

Practice

Verify your site and submit one sitemap. Note the date and status.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. What is a URL-prefix property?
   Answer: A property for one address pattern, such as https://www.example.com/blog/.
2. Why submit a sitemap?
   Answer: It lists pages you want found. It does not guarantee indexing.

Key takeaways

- Verify the site.
- Submit the sitemap.
- Check indexing regularly.

LECTURE 6.6 · PILLARS: OPTIMISE

Website speed

Find slow pages and fix the biggest causes of delay.

Learning objective

Find slow pages and fix the biggest causes of delay.

Core Web Vitals (current)

Metric	What it measures	Good (75th percentile)
LCP	Loading the main content	2.5 seconds or less
INP	Response to interaction	200 milliseconds or less
CLS	Unexpected layout shifts	0.1 or less

- Compress and resize images; use WebP or AVIF where your site supports them.
- Remove unused plugins and scripts.
- Use caching carefully, one plugin at a time, and test after each change.

Tools: PageSpeed Insights shows lab data (a test run) and field data (real users, where available).

CURRENT SEO PRACTICE / VERIFY

PageSpeed scores of 80 or more are a useful internal target, not a Google ranking requirement. A score of 100 is not needed to rank.

Practice

Test three of your pages. Fix the largest image on each, then test again.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. What does LCP measure?
   Answer: How fast the main content loads.
2. Is a 100 score required?
   Answer: No.

Key takeaways

- Use the three Core Web Vitals.
- Lab data and field data differ.
- Fix one change at a time.

Mobile SEO

Check that your site works on phones, because Google uses mobile content for indexing.

Learning objective

Check that your site works on phones, because Google uses mobile content for indexing.

- Test menus, buttons and forms with your thumb, on a real phone.
- Check text size and that nothing scrolls sideways.
- Use PageSpeed Insights and browser device view.

CURRENT SEO PRACTICE / VERIFY

Google's standalone Mobile-Friendly Test has been discontinued. Use PageSpeed Insights, Search Console and real-device tests instead.

Practice

Open your homepage and one service page on your phone. List three things that are hard to use.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Which test replaced the Mobile-Friendly Test?
   Answer: Use PageSpeed Insights, Search Console and real-device tests.
2. What is mobile-first indexing?
   Answer: Google mainly uses the mobile version of your content.

Key takeaways

- Test on a real phone.
- No sideways scrolling.
- Forms must be easy to finish on a phone.

LECTURE 6.8 · PILLARS: CREATE

Keyword funnel and portfolio

Match keywords to the buyer's stage, and build a mix rather than chasing one big word.

Learning objective

Match keywords to the buyer's stage, and build a mix rather than chasing one big word.

Stage	Example	Intent
Top	What is digital marketing?	Learn
Middle	Digital marketing career skills	Compare
Bottom	Best digital marketing course for beginners	Decide

Build a portfolio: a few head terms, many long-tail terms, and pages for each stage.



Match each page to one stage and one intent

Practice

Write one top, one middle and one bottom keyword for your business.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. What is a long-tail keyword?
   Answer: A longer, more specific phrase with clearer intent.
2. What stage is 'best course for beginners'?
   Answer: Bottom: close to a decision.

Key takeaways

- Match keywords to intent.
- Use a mix of head and long-tail.
- Plan one page per topic.

LECTURE 6.9 · PILLARS: CREATE

Brainstorming keyword ideas

Generate a large list of keyword ideas from free and low-cost sources.

Learning objective

Generate a large list of keyword ideas from free and low-cost sources.

- Google Autocomplete and Related Searches.
- People Also Ask questions in the results.
- Keyword Planner in Google Ads (you may need an account; volumes are ranges).
- Ubersuggest, with a free and paid plan.
- Quora and community threads for real wording.

Put every idea in a spreadsheet. Group similar ideas into topics so you do not build two pages that compete with each other.

CURRENT SEO PRACTICE / VERIFY

Keyword expansion tools change often. Check output relevance and data before you use it.



Each group becomes one page

Practice

Collect 50 keyword ideas for one topic and group them into five themes.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Why group keywords?
   Answer: To avoid pages that compete with each other.
2. Why are Keyword Planner volumes ranges?
   Answer: They vary by account and settings.

Key takeaways

- Collect many ideas.
- Group them into themes.
- Check the data before you rely on it.

Filtering and prioritising keywords

Pick keywords you can realistically rank for and that match your business.

Learning objective

Pick keywords you can realistically rank for and that match your business.

Look at volume, intent, competition, cost per click and relevance. A practice filter might be 500 to 2,500 monthly searches. This is a teaching example, not a rule.

- Cost per click shows advertiser demand, not proof of organic conversions.
- A lower-volume query with clear buying intent can be worth more than a broad question.

Practice

Score your 50 keywords on the four factors from Lecture 6.9 and keep the top ten.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Is a high volume always best?
   Answer: No. Intent and realistic competition matter.
2. What does CPC tell you?
   Answer: Advertiser demand, not organic results.

Key takeaways

- Balance volume, intent and competition.
- CPC is a clue, not a proof.
- Pick a realistic top ten.

LECTURE 6.11 · PILLARS: OPTIMISE · CREATE

Competitor analysis and keyword selection

Study the results page and choose one main topic for each page.

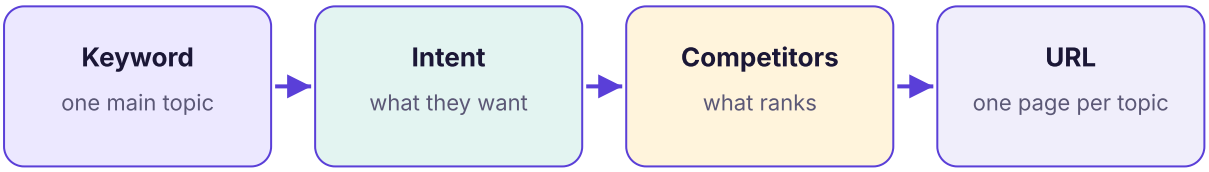
Learning objective

Study the results page and choose one main topic for each page.

- Search each target keyword and note the page types on page 1.
- Compare depth, format and freshness with your planned page.
- Check referring domains with Ahrefs, Moz or similar tools.
- Map each keyword to one URL in a spreadsheet.

CURRENT SEO PRACTICE / VERIFY

Domain Authority (Moz) and Domain Rating (Ahrefs) are third-party scores. They are not Google ranking factors. Do not use them as a promise of ranking.



One main topic per URL

Practice

Build a keyword-to-URL map for five pages.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Is Domain Authority a Google ranking factor?
   Answer: No. It is a third-party comparison score.
2. How many main keywords per page?
   Answer: One main topic.

Key takeaways

- Study the real results.
- One main topic per URL.
- Third-party scores are comparisons only.

LECTURE 6.12 · PILLARS: CREATE · IMPLEMENT

Title tags, URLs and meta descriptions

Write a clear title, a short URL and a useful description.

Learning objective

Write a clear title, a short URL and a useful description.

Element	Poor	Better
Title	Our Services | Home	SEO Services for Small Shops | Your Brand
URL	/page?id=123	/seo-services-small-shops
Description	Welcome to our website.	Clear monthly SEO for small shops: keyword plan, page fixes and a simple report.

- Put the main topic near the start of the title.
- Use hyphens between words in URLs.
- Aim for about 50 to 60 characters for titles and about 150 to 160 for descriptions as writing guides.

CURRENT SEO PRACTICE / VERIFY

Google may rewrite titles and descriptions in results. Lengths are guides, not limits.

Practice

Rewrite the title, URL and description of one page and check each length.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Are character counts a Google rule?
   Answer: No. They are writing guides.
2. Why hyphens in URLs?
   Answer: Search engines read hyphens as word separators.

Key takeaways

- Main topic first in the title.
- Short, descriptive URLs with hyphens.
- Descriptions state the benefit.

LECTURE 6.13 · PILLARS: IMPLEMENT · OPTIMISE

Image optimisation

Make images fast and useful for people and search engines.

Learning objective

Make images fast and useful for people and search engines.

- Name files descriptively, for example seo-checklist-phone.webp.
- Compress and resize before upload. Use WebP or AVIF where supported, or JPEG or PNG.
- Write alt text that describes the image in one short line. Use empty alt text for purely decorative images.
- Create graphics in Canva and export at a sensible size.

Practice

Optimise three images on one page: rename, compress and add alt text.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. What is alt text for?
   Answer: Describing the image for screen readers and when an image cannot load.
2. What is alt text for a decorative image?
   Answer: Empty.

Key takeaways

- Descriptive file names.
- Compress and resize.
- Alt text for meaningful images.

LECTURE 6.14 · PILLARS: CREATE

Content and heading structure

Organise content so readers and search engines follow the topic.

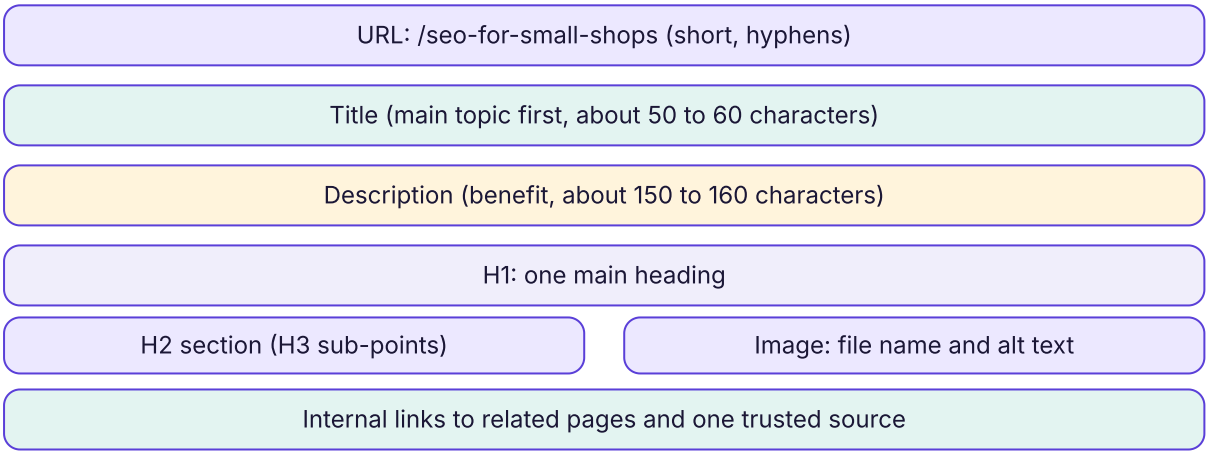
Learning objective

Organise content so readers and search engines follow the topic.

- One H1 for the main topic.
- H2 for main sections, H3 for sub-points.
- Answer the searcher's question in the first paragraphs.
- Add tables, examples and an FAQ where it helps.

COMMON MISTAKE

Do not choose headings only for their size. Use them to show structure.



Practice

Turn one article into a clear H1, five H2s and an FAQ with three questions.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. How many H1 headings should a page use?
   Answer: One.
2. What is an H2 for?
   Answer: A main section.

Key takeaways

- One H1.
- Logical H2 and H3.
- Answer early and clearly.

LECTURE 6.15 · PILLARS: IMPLEMENT

Internal and external links

Link related pages to each other, and link to trustworthy sources.

Learning objective

Link related pages to each other, and link to trustworthy sources.

- Link related supporting articles to your main page with descriptive anchor text.
- Find pages with no internal links (orphan pages) and link to them.
- Link to reliable sources when you make a claim, and check each one.

Opening links in a new tab is a personal choice, not an SEO requirement. Normal same-tab links are fine.

Practice

Find three orphan pages and add one internal link to each.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Is opening a link in a new tab an SEO requirement?
   Answer: No.
2. What makes anchor text useful?
   Answer: It describes the destination.

Key takeaways

- Descriptive internal links.
- Cite trustworthy sources.
- Fix orphan pages.

LECTURE 6.16 · PILLARS: UNDERSTAND · OPTIMISE

Backlinks that matter

Understand what backlinks are and how link attributes work.

Learning objective

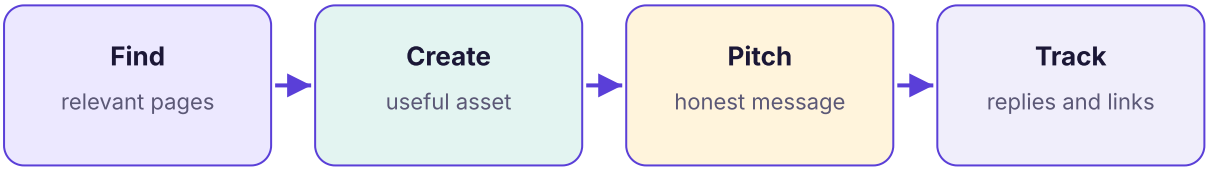
Understand what backlinks are and how link attributes work.

A backlink is a link from another site to yours. A referring domain is a site that links to you at least once.

- A normal link has no attribute.
- rel="nofollow" tells search engines not to endorse the link. Sponsored and UGC attributes describe paid and user-created links.
- These attributes are hints about the link. They are not a simple on-off switch for all SEO value.

CURRENT SEO PRACTICE / VERIFY

Search Central's link attribute guidance: developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/qualify-outbound-links



Earn links honestly; never buy them

Practice

List five links you can see pointing to a competitor and label each one's attribute.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Are nofollow links worthless?
   Answer: Not necessarily: they are hints, and they can still bring visitors.
2. What does sponsored mean?
   Answer: A paid or sponsored placement.

Key takeaways

- Backlinks come from other sites.
- Attributes are hints.
- Quality beats quantity.

LECTURE 6.17 · PILLARS: APPLY

Outreach and reclaiming links

Ask relevant sites for links honestly, and fix broken links that point to you.

Learning objective

Ask relevant sites for links honestly, and fix broken links that point to you.

- Find resource pages on relevant sites.
- Pitch a useful resource, personally, with one clear reason.
- Ask for corrections where a link points to a broken or old page.
- Reclaim unlinked mentions of your brand by asking for a link.

CURRENT SEO PRACTICE / VERIFY

The 5 percent response rate in the course is an illustrative scenario, not a benchmark. Some outreach gets no reply at all.

Practice

Write one outreach email for a resource page. Keep it under 120 words.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Is paid link buying allowed?
   Answer: Paid links that aim to manipulate rankings break Google's spam policies.
2. What is a broken-link pitch?
   Answer: Telling a site its broken link can point to your useful page.

Key takeaways

- Pitch relevant pages honestly.
- Avoid paid or automated links.
- Track each contact.

LECTURE 6.18 · PILLARS: CREATE · APPLY

Content that earns links

Publish useful assets that people want to link to.

Learning objective

Publish useful assets that people want to link to.

- Original research or a survey with real data.
- A curated resource list.
- A calculator or template people can use.
- An infographic or chart with a clear source.
- An expert roundup with real contributors.

CURRENT SEO PRACTICE / VERIFY

Content quality is the reason a link is earned. Do not invent data for a link asset.

Practice

Plan one asset: write the question, the data you will collect and who would link to it.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. What makes a linkable asset?
   Answer: Original, useful, accurate content.
2. Should you invent a statistic?
   Answer: No.

Key takeaways

- Make something useful.
- Original data needs a real source.
- Plan who would link to it.

LECTURE 6.19 · PILLARS: APPLY

Publishing on high-authority platforms

Use platforms such as YouTube, Quora, Udemy and SlideShare for visibility and referral traffic, without expecting a shortcut.

Learning objective

Use platforms such as YouTube, Quora, Udemy and SlideShare for visibility and referral traffic, without expecting a shortcut.

Publishing helpful videos, answers or courses on large platforms can bring visibility, referral traffic and brand awareness. Those pages can rank on their own platform.

COMMON MISTAKE

The reference claim that a new site can rank on Google page 1 within days by using platform authority is not supported. Platform authority does not transfer to your own site. Your site still needs relevant, helpful content and trust.

CURRENT SEO PRACTICE / VERIFY

Check each platform's current rules for links and self-promotion before you publish.

Practice

Choose one platform and plan one helpful answer that points to a page on your site where relevant.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Does a high-authority platform give your site its authority?
   Answer: No.
2. What can platform publishing bring?
   Answer: Visibility, referral traffic and awareness.

Key takeaways

- Platforms bring visibility.
- Authority does not transfer.
- No shortcut to page 1.

LECTURE 6.20 · PILLARS: APPLY

The Poster Boy Formula

Use a documented success story to earn coverage and links, honestly.

Learning objective

Use a documented success story to earn coverage and links, honestly.

1. Pick a company or tool your audience uses.
2. Use it to get a measurable result.
3. Document the problem, process and outcome with real numbers.
4. Write a credible case study.
5. Pitch the story to the company or a relevant publication.
6. Offer a useful resource.
7. Ask for a mention or a link where it fits.

CURRENT SEO PRACTICE / VERIFY

Coverage and links are never guaranteed. Only publish results you can prove. The name is a course term.

Practice

Write a one-paragraph case study outline for a real result you have. If you have none, plan the test you will run.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. What must a case study contain?
   Answer: A real, documented result.
2. Can you promise a link?
   Answer: No.

Key takeaways

- Document a real result.
- Pitch honestly.
- Links are earned, not promised.

LECTURE 6.21 · PILLARS: OPTIMISE

Student questions, part 1

Answer common questions about checking rankings, backlinks and disavow.

Learning objective

Answer common questions about checking rankings, backlinks and disavow.

- Personalised results can differ. Use a private window, or a tool that checks rankings from a neutral location.
- Incognito mode hides your history, but it does not show a fully neutral result.
- Suspicious backlinks come from unrelated sites, spam pages or paid networks. Check each one before deciding.
- Google's disavow tool is for advanced cases, such as a manual action for unnatural links. Most sites do not need it.
- Do not disavow links just because a third-party tool labels them toxic.

Practice

Check one keyword in a private window and record the top five results.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. When is disavow appropriate?
   Answer: Advanced cases only, usually after a manual action.
2. Does incognito give neutral results?
   Answer: It hides history, but results still vary.

Key takeaways

- Check rankings carefully.
- Disavow is advanced.
- Never disavow on a tool's label alone.

LECTURE 6.22 · PILLARS: OPTIMISE · UNDERSTAND

Student questions, part 2

Understand indexing, ranking, declining content and how to judge progress.

Learning objective

Understand indexing, ranking, declining content and how to judge progress.

- Crawling is finding a page. Indexing is storing it. Ranking is ordering it for a query. A page can be indexed and still rank poorly.
- A page can be indexed and get no traffic if no one searches for its topic or it does not match intent.
- Refresh declining content: check intent, update facts, improve the headings and add real examples.
- Judge progress over time: review at 30, 60 and 90 days, not one week.

Practice

Write a 30, 60 and 90 day review plan for one page with the metrics you will check.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. What is the difference between indexing and ranking?
   Answer: Indexing stores a page; ranking orders it.
2. When should you judge SEO progress?
   Answer: Over 30, 60 and 90 days.

Key takeaways

- Crawl, index and rank are different.
- Refresh content with real updates.
- Review over months.

LECTURE 6.23 · PILLARS: IMPLEMENT · OPTIMISE

Local SEO and Google Business Profile

Help a local business appear in Google Maps and local results, with accurate information.

Learning objective

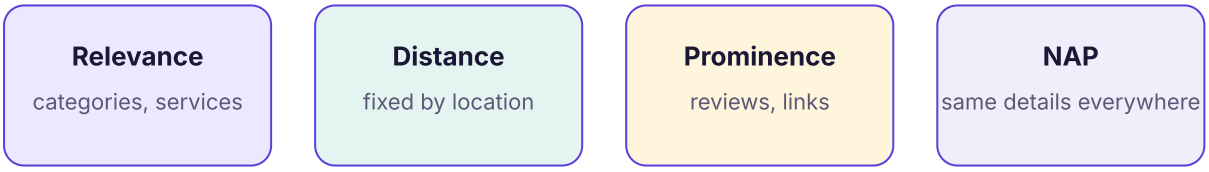
Help a local business appear in Google Maps and local results, with accurate information.

Google describes local ranking through relevance, distance and prominence. You cannot change distance, but you can improve relevance and prominence with accurate information and genuine reviews.

1. Create or claim your profile at Google Business Profile.
2. Complete verification using the method Google offers.
3. Choose accurate primary and secondary categories.
4. Add services, photos, hours and a clear description.
5. Keep Name, Address and Phone identical everywhere. This is called NAP consistency.
6. Ask real customers for reviews, and reply to every review politely.
7. Build local listings on relevant directories. In India, check current local directory rules before you list.

CURRENT SEO PRACTICE / VERIFY

Verification methods and profile features change. Check Google's Business Profile Help: support.google.com/business/



Google describes local ranking through these three concepts

Practice

Audit one local business profile against the seven steps and list three gaps.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. What are the three local ranking concepts?
   Answer: Relevance, distance and prominence.
2. What is NAP?
   Answer: Name, Address and Phone number.

Key takeaways

- Accurate, complete profile.
- Consistent NAP.
- Genuine reviews and replies.

LECTURE 6.24 · PILLARS: APPLY

Final assignment and knowledge mastery

Show what you learned on a real website, and test yourself with the quiz.

Learning objective

Show what you learned on a real website, and test yourself with the quiz.

1. Choose a real site or a practice WordPress site.
2. Analyse competitors and run a technical audit.
3. Check Analytics 4 and Search Console, and inspect the sitemap.
4. Run PageSpeed Insights on key pages.
5. Build a keyword list and a keyword-to-page map.
6. Optimise the homepage, titles, descriptions and images.
7. Audit internal links and one page's content.
8. Plan ethical outreach and, if local, audit the business profile.

Rubric (out of 100)

Area	Marks
Technical SEO	20
Keyword research	20
On-page optimisation	25
Off-page strategy	15
Local SEO	10
Reporting and presentation	10

The 10-question quiz is at the end of this chapter, with answers.

Practice

Complete the eight steps on one site and send the rubric self-score.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Which area is worth the most marks?
   Answer: On-page optimisation (25).
2. What is part of the submission?
   Answer: Website URL, keyword list, audit and before and after examples.

Key takeaways

- Practise on a real site.
- Use the rubric to self-score.
- Record evidence.

SKILLNAVORA DEMONSTRATION PROJECT

Use three of your own pages, or a demo site, as the running project. For each lecture 6.12 to 6.15, record the poor version, the improved version, why it is better, the steps, how you verified it, and one exercise.

RESOURCES · AI PROMPT LIBRARY

AI-assisted SEO prompts (20)

Copy a prompt, fill in the [brackets], then check every output yourself.

No.	Purpose	Prompt
1	Keyword brainstorm	Brainstorm 40 long-tail keyword ideas for [business] in [city, India] for people who want to [goal]. Group them by intent.
2	Search intent	Classify these keywords as informational, commercial, transactional or navigational: [list].
3	Keyword clusters	Group these keywords into topic clusters, one main topic each: [list].
4	Competitor gap	Compare these pages on depth, format and missing questions: [URLs or pasted text].
5	Content brief	Write an SEO content brief for [keyword]: intent, outline with H2s, questions to answer, and sources to check.
6	Title ideas	Write 10 titles for [topic], each about 50 to 60 characters, main topic first.
7	Meta description	Write 3 meta descriptions for [page], each about 150 to 160 characters, with one benefit.
8	Content outline	Outline a 1,000-word article on [topic] with one H1, H2 and H3 headings and an FAQ.
9	Internal links	Suggest 5 internal links from this article to my other pages: [list of titles].
10	FAQ research	List 10 questions people ask about [topic] and suggest short answers to check.
11	Local SEO	Write a Google Business Profile description for [business] in under 750 characters. Do not add claims I have not confirmed.
12	Technical audit reading	Explain this PageSpeed report in plain words and list the top three fixes: [paste report].
13	Refresh plan	Look at this old article and list what to update, remove and add: [paste text].
14	Backlink outreach	Write a 100-word outreach email to a site with a resource page on [topic]. Offer one useful resource.
15	SEO report	Write a monthly SEO summary for a non-technical owner from these numbers: [numbers]. Do not guess causes.
16	GA4 analysis	Explain what this GA4 organic report shows and list three questions to investigate: [paste].
17	Search Console analysis	Explain these Search Console changes in plain words and suggest checks: [paste].
18	Schema draft	Draft FAQ structured data for these questions and answers: [paste]. Remind me to validate it.
19	Strategy 90 days	Make a 90-day SEO plan for [business] with one goal per month and a tracking metric.
20	Fact check list	List every factual or numerical claim in this text so I can verify each one: [text].

COMMON MISTAKE

AI can invent search volumes, rankings and backlinks. Verify every keyword volume, ranking and link in Keyword Planner, Search Console or the source site.

CURRENT SEO PRACTICE / VERIFY

Validation: check each output against a real source, and remove anything you cannot prove.

AI-assisted SEO prompts (20), with purpose, output and validation

Use the full prompt text from the previous section. Fill the [brackets], then validate the output yourself using the table below.

No.	Use	Expected output	How to validate
1	Keyword brainstorm *Purpose: Find ideas quickly* When: Start of research	40 long-tail ideas grouped by intent	Check each in Keyword Planner or autocomplete
2	Search intent *Purpose: Label keywords* When: When filtering keywords	Each keyword with a label	Spot-check ten against the SERP
3	Keyword clusters *Purpose: Group into topics* When: Before writing a plan	Clusters with one main topic each	Make sure no two clusters compete
4	Competitor gap *Purpose: Compare pages* When: During competitor analysis	List of missing questions	Verify each gap on the live page
5	Content brief *Purpose: Plan an article* When: Before writing	Outline with headings and questions	Check sources and headings against the SERP
6	Title ideas *Purpose: Write titles* When: Titles stage	10 titles with lengths	Count characters; read as a stranger
7	Meta description *Purpose: Write summaries* When: Descriptions stage	3 descriptions of about 150 to 160 characters	Check each is unique and accurate
8	Content outline *Purpose: Structure an article* When: Drafting	H1, H2 and H3 outline with FAQ	Compare with the top results
9	Internal links *Purpose: Suggest links* When: Internal linking audit	5 link suggestions	Check each target page exists
10	FAQ research *Purpose: Find questions* When: Content gap	10 questions with short answers	Verify answers from sources
11	Local SEO description *Purpose: Write a profile description* When: Local stage	One description under 750 characters	Remove any claim you have not confirmed

12	PageSpeed reading *Purpose: Explain a report* When: After a speed test	Plain summary and three fixes	Retest after each fix
13	Refresh plan *Purpose: Update old content* When: Monthly review	What to update, remove or add	Check each fact is current
14	Backlink outreach *Purpose: Write a pitch* When: Outreach stage	100-word email	Read it aloud; check the offer is honest
15	SEO report *Purpose: Monthly summary* When: Reporting	Plain-language summary	Check every number against the source data
16	GA4 analysis *Purpose: Explain organic data* When: Measurement	Three questions to investigate	Check figures in GA4 itself
17	Search Console analysis *Purpose: Explain changes* When: Measurement	Likely causes to check	Check the dates and the report
18	Schema draft *Purpose: Draft structured data* When: Technical stage	Draft JSON-LD for FAQs	Validate in the Rich Results Test
19	90-day plan *Purpose: Plan three months* When: Strategy	One goal and metric per month	Review monthly against real data
20	Fact check list *Purpose: List claims to verify* When: Any copy	Numbered list of claims	Verify each claim before publishing

VALIDATE EVERY AI OUTPUT

AI can invent search volumes, rankings, backlinks and quotes. Check every number and link in Keyword Planner, Search Console, GA4 or the source site before you rely on it.

RESOURCES · CASE STUDIES

Five SEO case studies (hypothetical)

Each case is invented for learning and labelled as such.

These are invented businesses and imagined results. They are for learning. Do not present any number as a real company's result.

Digital marketing training institute (hypothetical)

Background	A small institute in a mid-size Indian city wants more online enquiries for weekend courses.
Keyword strategy	Local and course keywords with clear intent, such as course names with the city.
Technical work	Fix speed and mobile form issues. Set up GA4 and Search Console.
On-page	Course pages with one main keyword each, FAQ and clear calls to action.
Off-page	Ethical outreach to education blogs. Link to the institute's own course pages.
Local SEO	Complete Google Business Profile with accurate class schedules.
Measurement	Enquiries from organic visits per month, tracked in GA4.

Real estate agency (hypothetical)

Background	A local agency wants more buyers asking about flats in two areas.
Keyword strategy	Area-plus-need keywords, for example 2 BHK flats near a named area.
Technical work	Clean up duplicate listing pages. Check mobile search forms.
On-page	Area pages with local facts you can verify, not invented prices.
Off-page	Local news and community pages for links, where relevant.
Local SEO	Profile with photos and services, and consistent contact details.
Measurement	Enquiries and map clicks per month.

E-commerce store (hypothetical)

Background	A small online store sells handmade products and wants more organic sales.
Keyword strategy	Product and buyer-guide keywords with purchase intent.
Technical work	Product page speed and image sizes. Check duplicate product titles.
On-page	Product titles and descriptions written for each product, with real specifications.
Off-page	Guest posts on craft blogs, honestly disclosed.
Local SEO	Not needed unless the store has a shop location.
Measurement	Organic revenue and product page conversions in GA4.

B2B SaaS company (hypothetical)

Background	A software firm wants trial sign-ups from operations managers.

Keyword strategy	Problem-led keywords and comparison pages with clear intent.
Technical work	Core Web Vitals on landing pages. Structured data checked in the Rich Results Test.
On-page	Use-case pages with clear headings and a single call to action.
Off-page	Original research or a survey with real data as a linkable asset.
Local SEO	Not applicable.
Measurement	Organic trial sign-ups and keyword visibility over 90 days.

Local service business (hypothetical)

Background	A plumber in a city wants more calls from people nearby.
Keyword strategy	Service-plus-area keywords with emergency or same-day intent.
Technical work	Mobile click-to-call and fast load on phones.
On-page	One page per service and area, with accurate details.
Off-page	Local directory listings with the same name, address and phone.
Local SEO	Google Business Profile with reviews, services, hours and replies.
Measurement	Calls and direction requests per month from the profile.

RESOURCES · ROADMAP

30-day SEO roadmap

About 45 to 60 minutes a day, or about 5 to 6 hours a week for a working professional.

Day	Week theme	Activity, expected output and tool	Done
Day 1	SEO foundations and technical setup	GA4 and Search Console set up *Tool: Google Analytics 4*	☐
Day 2	SEO foundations and technical setup	Sitemap submitted *Tool: Spreadsheet or editor*	☐
Day 3	SEO foundations and technical setup	PageSpeed test on 3 pages *Tool: PageSpeed Insights*	☐
Day 4	SEO foundations and technical setup	Mobile check on a real phone *Tool: Spreadsheet or editor*	☐
Day 5	SEO foundations and technical setup	Homepage title and description *Tool: Yoast SEO*	☐
Day 6	SEO foundations and technical setup	Checklist stage A complete *Tool: Spreadsheet or editor*	☐
Day 7	Keyword research and competitor analysis	50 keyword ideas *Tool: Keyword Planner or Ubersuggest*	☐
Day 8	Keyword research and competitor analysis	Volume and CPC check *Tool: Spreadsheet or editor*	☐
Day 9	Keyword research and competitor analysis	Filter to top 10 *Tool: Spreadsheet or editor*	☐
Day 10	Keyword research and competitor analysis	Competitor SERP review *Tool: Manual SERP check, Ahrefs or Moz*	☐
Day 11	Keyword research and competitor analysis	Keyword-to-URL map *Tool: Keyword Planner or Ubersuggest*	☐
Day 12	Keyword research and competitor analysis	Checklist stage B complete *Tool: Spreadsheet or editor*	☐
Day 13	On-page SEO and content optimisation	Titles and descriptions for 5 pages *Tool: Yoast SEO*	☐
Day 14	On-page SEO and content optimisation	Image optimisation *Tool: Canva and a compression tool*	☐
Day 15	On-page SEO and content optimisation	Headings in 3 articles *Tool: Spreadsheet or editor*	☐
Day 16	On-page SEO and content optimisation	Internal link audit *Tool: Crawler or audit template*	☐
Day 17	On-page SEO and content optimisation	One content refresh *Tool: Spreadsheet or editor*	☐
Day 18	On-page SEO and content optimisation	Checklist stage C complete *Tool: Spreadsheet or editor*	☐

Day 19	Link building, local SEO and measurement	Backlink opportunity list (10) *Tool: Ahrefs or Majestic*	☐
Day 20	Link building, local SEO and measurement	3 outreach emails *Tool: Email and spreadsheet*	☐
Day 21	Link building, local SEO and measurement	Business profile audit *Tool: Google Business Profile*	☐
Day 22	Link building, local SEO and measurement	Monthly report template *Tool: Spreadsheet*	☐
Day 23	Link building, local SEO and measurement	30-day review *Tool: Spreadsheet*	☐
Day 24	Link building, local SEO and measurement	Checklist stage D complete *Tool: Spreadsheet or editor*	☐

RESOURCES · TEMPLATES

Practical SEO templates

Each template has the columns to copy and one example row. Replace the example with your own data.

Template	Columns	Example row
Keyword research	Keyword, intent, volume range, CPC, difficulty note, decision (keep or drop)	sample row: best CRM for small shops | commercial | 500 to 2,500 | medium | keep
Buyer persona	Who, goal, problem, search words, objections	Asha, 35, runs a boutique; wants steady bookings; searches 'booking app for salon'
Competitor analysis	Competitor, page type, depth, headings, links, gap	Competitor A, guide, 2,000 words, no FAQ, gap: local examples
Keyword-to-URL map	Keyword, URL, intent, status, owner	best crm for small shops | /crm-for-small-shops | commercial | to do
Technical SEO audit	Check, page, status, fix, priority	Missing sitemap | all | fail | submit sitemap | high
On-page SEO audit	Title, description, H1, URL, images, links	Title 72 characters | /home | fix | high
Content brief	Keyword, intent, outline, questions, sources	Keyword: seo for beginners | informational | H2 list | FAQ
SEO content optimisation	Before and after per element	Title: 'SEO Tips' becomes 'SEO for Beginners: 7 Steps That Work'
Backlink prospecting	Site, page, why relevant, contact, status	example-blog.in | resource page | relevant | editor email | not contacted
Backlink outreach tracking	Contact, date, reply, outcome, next step	Editor A | 2 Dec | no reply | follow-up 9 Dec
Local SEO audit	Profile item, status, fix	Categories | incomplete | add secondary category
Monthly SEO report	Metric, this month, last month, comment, action	Organic enquiries | 12 | 9 | new page live | keep

WORKBOOK

Practical exercises (7)

Each exercise has instructions, a deliverable, criteria and space for your notes.

1. SERP analysis

Analyse five keywords: intent, page types, competitors, SERP features, content opportunity.

Deliverable: Five rows completed.

Evaluation: complete, accurate, specific, and checked against a source.

Your notes:

2. Keyword research

Generate 50 ideas. Classify by intent, funnel stage, volume range, competition and relevance. Select 10.

Deliverable: Sheet with 50 rows and a top 10.

Evaluation: complete, accurate, specific, and checked against a source.

Your notes:

3. Technical audit

Audit one site with Search Console, PageSpeed Insights and a crawler if available. Test on a real phone.

Deliverable: Audit list with priorities.

Evaluation: complete, accurate, specific, and checked against a source.

Your notes:

4. On-page SEO

Optimise one real page: title, description, URL, H1 and H2s, image alt, internal links.

Deliverable: Before and after table.

Evaluation: complete, accurate, specific, and checked against a source.

Your notes:

5. Backlink strategy

Identify 10 realistic opportunities and write 3 personalised outreach emails.

Deliverable: Opportunity list and 3 emails.

Evaluation: complete, accurate, specific, and checked against a source.

Your notes:

6. Local SEO

Audit one Business Profile, or plan one for a demo business.

Deliverable: Audit checklist.

Evaluation: complete, accurate, specific, and checked against a source.

Your notes:

7. Final strategy

Write a mini SEO strategy for a real or hypothetical business.

Deliverable: One-page strategy.

Evaluation: complete, accurate, specific, and checked against a source.

Your notes:

ASSESSMENT

10-question quiz with four options, answers and explanations

Answer on paper first. The answer key with explanations is below.

1. What mainly drives how Google ranks results?

A. Domain age and social shares
B. Relevance and authority
C. Keyword density
D. Ad spend

2. What click share does position 1 get?

A. About 10 percent
B. About 50 percent
C. About 31 percent in an old study
D. Always 70 percent

3. What title length is a good writing guide?

A. 30 characters
B. 55 to 60 characters
C. 100 characters
D. 160 characters

4. How should words in a URL be separated?

A. Hyphens
B. Underscores
C. Plus signs
D. Nothing

5. What PageSpeed score is a sensible internal target?

A. 50
B. 100 only
C. Any score
D. 80 or more

6. Which keyword type suits a new site?

A. Single broad words only
B. Branded terms only
C. Long-tail keywords with clear intent
D. Zero-search terms

7. What does nofollow tell search engines?

A. Ignore the page entirely
B. The link is paid
C. Block the visitor
D. The link should not be endorsed; it is a hint

8. Which link practice is safe?

A. Buying links in bulk

B. Automated link packages

C. Spam comments

D. Earning links with useful content and honest outreach

9. What does NAP mean in local SEO?

A. Network Access Protocol

B. Net advertising profit

C. New audience persona

D. Name, Address, Phone number

10. Can a new site reach page 1 within days by posting on a high-authority platform?

A. Yes, always

B. Yes, if you pay

C. Only on Fridays

D. No, platform authority does not transfer to your site

Answer key

1. **B. Relevance and authority**
   Why correct: Relevance and authority are core ideas.
   Why the others are wrong: A: Domain age is not a simple factor; social shares are not a direct ranking factor. C: Keyword density stuffing is not a goal; it can hurt readability. D: Ad spend does not affect organic ranking.
2. **C. About 31 percent in an old study**
   Why correct: An old study gave about 31 percent; shares vary by query and layout.
   Why the others are wrong: A: 10 percent is far too low for position 1 in historical studies. B: 50 percent is not a stable figure. D: 70 percent is the figure for all of page 1, not position 1.
3. **B. 55 to 60 characters**
   Why correct: About 50 to 60 is a writing guide, not a rule.
   Why the others are wrong: A: 30 is too short to state the topic. C: 100 is often cut off in results. D: 160 is the description length guide, not the title.
4. **A. Hyphens**
   Why correct: Search engines read hyphens as separators.
   Why the others are wrong: B: Underscores can join words together. C: Plus signs are not standard for words in a URL. D: Running words together makes them hard to read.
5. **D. 80 or more**
   Why correct: 80 or more is a learning target, not a ranking rule.
   Why the others are wrong: A: 50 is too low a target for most sites. B: 100 is not required to rank. C: Any score is not a target.
6. **C. Long-tail keywords with clear intent**
   Why correct: Long-tail phrases are specific and easier to win.
   Why the others are wrong: A: Broad words are very hard for a new site. B: Branded terms only helps people who already know you. D: Zero-search terms have no demand.
7. **D. The link should not be endorsed; it is a hint**
   Why correct: Nofollow is a hint, not a total switch.

Why the others are wrong: A: Nofollow does not make search engines ignore the page. B: Nofollow does not mean the link is paid; sponsored does. C: Nofollow does not block visitors.

8. **D. Earning links with useful content and honest outreach**
   Why correct: Earning links honestly is the safe practice.
   Why the others are wrong: A: Bulk buying breaks spam policies. B: Automated packages break spam policies. C: Spam comments are not useful links.
9. **D. Name, Address, Phone number**
   Why correct: Keep your name, address and phone identical everywhere.
   Why the others are wrong: A: Network Access Protocol is a computing term, not this. B: Net advertising profit is not a local SEO term. C: New audience persona is a marketing term, not NAP.
10. **D. No, platform authority does not transfer to your site**
    Why correct: There is no such shortcut.
    Why the others are wrong: A: Not always: this is not guaranteed. B: Paying does not create rankings. C: No day of the week changes this.

Scoring

Score	Meaning
9 to 10	Excellent SEO foundation
7 to 8	Good understanding
5 to 6	Needs more practice
0 to 4	Revisit the lectures

RESOURCES · GLOSSARY

SEO glossary (65 terms)

Each term has a simple meaning, a practical example and why it matters.

Term	Simple meaning	Practical example	Why it matters
Crawling	Search engines fetching pages	Googlebot visits your new blog post	Pages must be reachable before they can rank
Indexing	Storing a page in the search index	Search Console says 'Indexed'	An unindexed page cannot appear in results
Ranking	Ordering results for a query	Your page appears 8th for a search	Ranking is the goal; it is not guaranteed
SERP	Search engine results page	The page of results for 'buy shoes'	You optimise for what is shown there
CTR	Clicks divided by impressions	50 clicks from 1,000 impressions = 5%	Shows if your title and description attract clicks
CPC	Cost per click in paid search	Ad clicks cost 20 each	Shows advertiser demand, a clue for SEO
Keyword difficulty	Third-party estimate of how hard to rank	A tool shows 45 out of 100	Helps choose realistic keywords
Search volume	Estimated monthly searches	Keyword Planner shows 500 to 1,000	Shows potential demand
Search intent	What the searcher wants	'best CRM' wants comparison	Pages must match intent
Head keyword	Short, broad term	'shoes'	Hard to rank for a new site
Long-tail keyword	Longer, specific phrase	'running shoes for flat feet in Pune'	Easier to win, more specific
Canonical URL	Preferred address for similar pages	The product page with ?colour=red points to the main page	Avoids duplicate content confusion
Schema markup	Structured data describing content	FAQ markup on an FAQ page	Helps search engines understand content
Backlink	A link from another site	A blog links to your guide	Signals trust when earned honestly
Referring domain	A site that links to you at least once	Ten different blogs link to you	More useful than counting links from one site
Robots.txt	File asking crawlers which parts to skip	Blocking /admin/	A mistake can block important pages
XML sitemap	List of pages for search engines	sitemap_index.xml	Helps discovery, does not guarantee indexing
Core Web Vitals	Speed, response and stability measures	LCP of 2.1 seconds	A page experience measure
LCP	Largest Contentful Paint: main content load time	Hero image loads in 2.1 s	Good is 2.5 seconds or less

INP	Interaction to Next Paint: response to input	A menu opens quickly	Good is 200 ms or less
CLS	Cumulative Layout Shift: unexpected movement	An ad pushes text down	Good is 0.1 or less
Mobile-first indexing	Google mainly uses the mobile version	Your phone page has less text	Phone content must be complete
Dofollow	Normal link with no nofollow attribute	A standard link in a post	Default link type
Nofollow	Attribute hinting not to endorse	A comment link	A hint, not a total switch
Sponsored	Attribute for paid links	An advert link in a blog	Required for paid placements
UGC	Attribute for user-created links	A forum signature link	Marks user-created links
Anchor text	Clickable words of a link	'SEO checklist'	Should describe the destination
Internal link	Link from one page of your site to another	Guide links to a tool page	Helps navigation and discovery
Orphan page	Page with no internal links	An old page no menu links to	Hard for users and crawlers to find
Redirect	Sending visitors to a new address	Old URL points to new URL	Keeps links and visitors working
301 redirect	Permanent redirect	/old to /new permanently	Used when a page moves for good
404 error	Page not found	A deleted post	Fix or redirect important ones
Duplicate content	Near-identical content on more than one address	Same text on two URLs	Confuses which version to show
Title tag	Page title shown in results and tabs	'SEO for Beginners | Your Brand'	First impression in results
Meta description	Summary that may appear in results	One sentence about the page	Can improve clicks; Google may rewrite it
Alt text	Short description of an image	'Phone showing SEO checklist'	Helps accessibility and image search
H1	Main heading of a page	'SEO for Small Shops'	One per page
H2 and H3	Section and sub-section headings	'Keyword research' as an H2	Show structure
Open Graph	Metadata for shared links	Preview image in WhatsApp	Better sharing previews
GA4	Google Analytics 4	Organic visits report	Current Google Analytics version

Conversion event	Key action such as a sign-up	'generate_lead' event	Measures results
Organic traffic	Visits from unpaid search results	Visits from Google search	Shows search contribution
Attribution	Deciding which channel gets credit	Last click or data-driven model	Credit splits differ by model
Impressions	How often a page appeared in results	Shown 1,000 times	Visibility measure
Average position	Typical position for a query	Average position 8.4	Helps track progress
Domain Authority	Moz third-party score	DA 35	Not a Google ranking factor
Page Authority	Moz third-party page score	PA 28	Comparison only
Domain Rating	Ahrefs third-party score	DR 40	Comparison only
Local SEO	Optimising for local searches and maps	'plumber near me'	Helps local customers find you
Google Business Profile	Free local listing	Your shop appears on Maps	Core local visibility tool
NAP	Name, Address, Phone number	Same phone number on all listings	Consistency helps trust
Citation	Business listing on another site	A directory entry	Adds consistent details
Review response	Public reply to a review	'Thank you, we have fixed it'	Shows care and activity
Disavow	Advanced tool to ignore certain links	Uploading a list after a manual action	Use only for clear problems
Manual action	Penalty from a human review of spam	A message in Search Console	Fix the problem and request review
Spam policy	Google's rules against manipulation	Paid link schemes	Breaking them can hurt rankings
Topic cluster	Main page with supporting pages	Guide to SEO with 6 sub-guides	Shows topical depth
Pillar page	Broad page linking to a cluster	'SEO basics' guide	Organises the cluster
Content refresh	Updating an existing page	Adding 2024 data to an old post	Keeps content useful
Link magnet	Asset people link to	An original survey	Earns links naturally
Digital PR	Earning coverage and links through stories	A case study pitched to a magazine	Coverage is not guaranteed

Poster Boy Formula	Course term: document a success story to pitch	A case study with real numbers	Pitch honestly

FINISH · ASSESSMENT CRITERIA

What beginner, competent and advanced work looks like

Use this table to judge your submission.

Area	Beginner	Competent	Advanced
Technical SEO (20)	GA4 and Search Console set up; sitemap submitted	Audit with fixes and before and after speed	Crawl analysis, structured data validated, redirect plan
Keyword research (20)	50 ideas and a top ten	Scored list and keyword-to-URL map	Cluster strategy with intent and competitor evidence
On-page (25)	Titles and descriptions for key pages	Before and after examples for five pages	Full page rewrites with internal links and measured changes
Off-page (15)	Opportunity list of ten	Three personalised outreach emails and a tracker	Asset plan with a tracked outreach campaign
Local (10)	Profile checked for NAP	Profile audit with a fix list	Profile plus local pages and review plan
Reporting (10)	One simple table	30, 60 and 90 day plan with metrics	Dashboard with insights and next actions

RESOURCES · OFFICIAL SOURCES

Official resources

Start with Google's own documentation. Check each link once before you rely on it.

- Google Search Central (official SEO docs)
- Google SEO Starter Guide
- Google Search Console Help
- Google Analytics documentation
- PageSpeed Insights
- Google Business Profile Help
- Google spam policies
- Rich Results Test
- Bing Webmaster Tools
- Yoast SEO

CURRENT SEO PRACTICE / VERIFY

These links point to official sources. They were not checked live from this workspace.

FINISH · SUBMISSION

Final submission and completion summary

Send these items with your website link.

Item	Done
Website URL	☐
Keyword research spreadsheet	☐
26-point checklist (completed)	☐
Before and after page examples	☐
Screenshots (Search Console, GA4, PageSpeed)	☐
Backlink opportunity list	☐
30, 60 and 90 day measurement plan	☐
One-page summary of recommendations	☐

Completion summary

Measure	Count
Lectures covered	24
SEO checklist points	26
Practical exercises	7
AI prompts	20
Case studies	5 (hypothetical)
Quiz questions	10